Bala Hisar to winter in Jalalabad, which, in the absence of Peshawar, he now named as his winter capital. Macnaghten went with him. Arriving ahead of Shuja, while the Shah was delayed burying a junior prince amid the poplars of the Nimla Gardens, Macnaghten took for himself the best quarters in town, leaving the Shah to shelter in what one British observer called ‘a hovel’.[33]

Mullah Shakur was left in charge in Kabul, with Burnes standing in for Macnaghten. On the last night of the year, as the winter cold grew more intense, Burnes threw a Hogmanay party, and presided over it all in kilt and sporran. Neville Chamberlain, up for the week from Kandahar, was one of the guests. ‘We had a very merry party,’ he wrote the following morning.

> Though we had nothing to drink but brandy and gin. At about 2 in the morning we took to the mess tables and commenced dancing reels, Captain Sinclair standing on the table, dressed in the Highland costume, playing the bagpipes. Burnes was extremely civil to us. He is liked by everyone, as there is no political humbug in him unlike most persons in that employ . . . [He is in fact] a general favourite, and very justly so as he is, I think, the most unaffected, gentlemanlike, pleasant and amusing man that I have had the good fortune to meet.[34]

The celebrations that continued in Kabul throughout the winter were not to everyone’s taste. The American adventurer ‘General’ Josiah Harlan, who had fought successively for the East India Company, Shah Shuja, the Sikhs and finally Dost Mohammad, and who claimed he had briefly had himself crowned the Prince of Ghor, looked on with an increasingly jaundiced eye at the British at play, before finally quitting Afghanistan in disgust. ‘Kabul, the city of a thousand gardens, in those days was a paradise,’ he wrote later on the steamer back home after Burnes had had him deported from India as an unwanted alien. ‘I have seen this country, sacred to the harmony of hallowed solitude, desecrated by the rude intrusion of senseless stranger boors, vile in habits, infamous in vulgar tastes, callous leaders in the sanguinary march of heedless conquests, who crushed the feeble heart and hushed the merry voice of mirth, hilarity and joy . . .’ He added prophetically, ‘To subdue and crush the masses of a nation by military force, when all are unanimous in the determination to be free, is to attempt the imprisonment of a whole people: all such projects must be temporary and transient, and terminate in a catastrophe . . .’[35]

Yet in that first winter of the occupation there were few signs that Harlan was anything more than an embittered old Afghan hand who had seen his